

END OF A DREAM, BEGINNING OF ANOTHER

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In the last decade, one of India's most promising industries has been online gaming: the internet became cheaper, so did smartphones, and a country of 1.4 billion people found a new favourite pastime.

And real-money gaming (RMG) took a prime spot in this ascend, creating an industry worth 20,000 crores, with companies like Dream11 and WinZO gaining over 500 million users (cumulative).

But the bubble burst in August 2025 when the Government of India introduced the Online Gaming Bill across both houses of parliament, eventually making it an Act. It prohibited real-money games in the country, leading to around 400 such companies winding down, affecting millions of users and nearly 2,00,000 employees.



"Obviously, we were shocked that we were being asked to shut down. The business model is going to shut down," Harsh Jain, the CEO of Dream 11, told *moneycontrol.com*. "We do believe regulation was the correct way forward, but we understand that this is not something that the government wants."

WHAT IS REAL-MONEY GAMING?

While the legality of RMG is a discussion for the country's executive, for a layman, it needs to be clarified what the term actually means and how that is different to conventional esports.

The Act defines an 'online money game' as any online game played by paying fees, depositing money, or other stakes with the "expectation of winning, which entails monetary and other enrichment".

Some of the most prominent games in this category were Dream11, PokerBaazi and WinZO, where a user had to deposit some money and depending on results or simulations – in real life (cricket, football) or

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